

Impact High · Difficulty Medium · Misuse risk Low

THE MOVE

Show you understood the concern -> Fully -> Before responding or defending

START HERE

Before addressing a concern, state it back in your own words to show you heard it. Then respond. Not before.

SAY THIS

Validation Phrases	<i>"I understand why that would be a concern."</i>
Full Understanding	<i>"Just to make sure I have the full picture — is the concern about X, or also about Y?"</i>
Stakeholder Validation	<i>"You are right to press on this — it is the part of the plan with the most risk."</i>
Validation Under Fire	<i>"You are angry, and given what happened, that is fair."</i>
Bridge to Response	<i>"Now that I understand it, here is what I can do about it."</i>

AVOID

- When the concern is unfounded and validating it would reinforce a false belief.
- In situations requiring urgent action where pausing to validate delays a critical response.
- When someone is using the concern manipulatively to avoid accountability.

REMEMBER

Validate the concern they meant, not the sentence they said.